Lennart Schürmann | Dr.

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Research profile

I am a social scientist specializing in political behavior, mobilization, and the political implications of societal transformation. My research explores how citizens mobilize beyond elections — through street, legal, and digital activism — and how institutions respond, using computational and (quasi-)experimental methods.

Academic positions

Current

European University Institute | Department of Political and Social Sciences — **Florence** (IT)
Max Weber Fellow — *Since Sep 2025*
- Mentor: *Simon Hix*

Freie Universität Berlin | Chair for Political Sociology — **Berlin** (DE)
Independent Post-Doctoral Researcher | DAAD PRIME Fellow — *Since Jul 2025*
- Hosted by: *Swen Hutter*

WZB Berlin Social Science Center | Center for Civil Society Research — **Berlin** (DE)
Post-Doctoral Research Fellow — *Since Jan 2023*
- Principal Investigator of the Project: 'Empowering Voices Beyond Ballots'
- Involved in the Project: 'Political Protest and Radicalization (MOTRA/ProtestMonitoring)'

Previous

Harvard University | Minda de Gunzburg Center for European Studies — **Cambridge** (US)
Post-Doctoral Fellow | Visiting Scholars Program hosted by Daniel Ziblatt — *Jan - Jun 2025*

University of Cologne | Cologne Center for Comparative Politics — **Cologne** (DE)
Doctoral Researcher — *Oct 2019 – Dec 2022*
- Conducted an Independently Funded PhD Project | Full Scholarship, *Cologne Graduate School*
- Member of the Chair for European and Multilevel Politics *(Sven-Oliver Proksch)*

Pompeu Fabra University | Institutions and Political Actors Research Group — **Barcelona** (ES)
Visiting Researcher with Toni Rodon — *Oct - Nov 2022*

WZB Berlin Social Science Center | Center for Civil Society Research — **Berlin** (DE)
Guest Researcher with Swen Hutter — *Jun - Jul 2022*

University of Amsterdam | Challenges to Democratic Representation Programme Group — **Amsterdam** (NL)
Visiting Researcher with Gijs Schumacher — *Sep - Dec 2021*

Education

University of Cologne — **Cologne** (DE)
Dr. rer. pol. (PhD) in Political Science — *2019 – 2023*
- Title: Political Representation and Protest Politics in European Democracies
- Supervisors: Sven-Oliver Proksch & Ingo Rohlfing
- Date of Defense: June 28th, 2023

Goethe University Frankfurt — **Frankfurt** (DE) | **Paris** (FR)
M.A. in Political Science — *2016 – 2019*
- Semester Abroad: EHESS School for Advanced Studies in the Social Sciences Paris

University of Cologne — **Cologne** (DE) | **Grenoble** (FR)
B.Sc. in Social Sciences (Political Science, Sociology and Economics) — *2013 – 2016*
- Semester Abroad: Grenoble Alpes University | Sciences Po Grenoble

Publications

Journal articles (peer reviewed)

[1] Saldivia Gonzatti, Daniel, **Lennart Schürmann**, Sophia Hunger & Swen Hutter (Forthcoming). How Confrontational Protest Shapes Public Opinion: Experimental Evidence from Climate Mobilization. *Political Behavior*.

[2] **Schürmann, Lennart** & Leonard Schmidt (2026). Street Mobilization during Election Campaigns in Multilevel Systems: A Supply-Demand Analysis. *West European Politics*.

[3] **Schürmann, Lennart**, Endre Borbáth, & Swen Hutter (2025). Protest and the rise of left-nationalist challengers: evidence from Germany. *Social Movement Studies.*

[4] **Schürmann, Lennart,** Jan Schwalbach, & Noam Himmelrath (2025). Location matters! Geospatial dynamics of MP responses to Covid-19 protests in multilevel systems. *European Journal of Political Research,* 64(2): 513 - 534.

[5] **Schürmann, Lennart** (2024). The impact of local protests on political elite communication: evidence from Fridays for Future in Germany. *Journal of Elections, Public Opinion and Parties,* 34(3): 510 - 530.

[6] Castanho Silva, Bruno, **Lennart Schürmann** & Sven-Oliver Proksch (2024). Modulation of Democracy: Partisan Communication during and after Election Campaigns. *British Journal of Political Science,* 54(2): 339 - 354.

[7] **Schürmann, Lennart** (2023). Do competitive districts get more political attention? Strategic use of geographic representation during campaign and non-campaign periods. *Electoral Studies* 81, Article 102575.

[8] **Schürmann, Lennart** & Sebastian Stier (2023). Who represents the constituency? Online political communication by members of parliament in the German mixed-member electoral system. *Legislative Studies Quarterly,* 48(1): 219–234.

Working papers

[1] Stephan, Meret & **Lennart Schürmann**. Conditional Allies: How Government Status, Policy Credibility and Electoral Viability Shape Electoral Benefits of Street Mobilization
- *Available as WZB Discussion Paper ZZ 2025(601).*

[2] **Schürmann, Lennart** & Teresa Völker. Defending Democracy: The Impact of State Action on Public Support for Democracy

[3] **Schürmann, Lennart**. Legal Mobilization and Public Trust in Democratic Institutions: Lessons from German Climate Crisis Litigation

Contributions to edited volumes

[1] **Schürmann, Lennart** & Swen Hutter (2026). Ist Kartoffelbrei auf Kunst weniger akzeptiert als politische Gewalt? Wie die Menschen in Deutschland die Legitimität und Effektivität von Protest einschätzen. In: *Extremistische Einstellungen in Deutschland: Verbreitungen, Einflussfaktoren und Trends*, eds. Rebecca Endtricht. Wiesbaden: Springer VS.

[2] Basu, Chitralekha & **Lennart Schürmann** (2025). Media Effects on Political Elites. In: *Edward Elgar Encyclopedia of Political Communication*, eds. Alessandro Nai, Max Grömping & Dominique Wirz. Cheltenham: Edward Elgar Publishing.

[3] Kanol, Eylem, Teresa Völker, Daniel Saldivia Gonzatti, **Lennart Schürmann** & Swen Hutter (2025). Politischer Protest und Radikalisierung: Befunde aus dem WZB ProtestMonitoring. In: *MOTRA-Monitor 2023/24.* Wiesbaden: Bundeskriminalamt - Forschungsstelle Terrorismus/Extremismus, pp. 154-185.

[4] Hutter, Swen, Eylem Kanol, Daniel Saldivia Gonzatti, **Lennart Schürmann**, Teresa Völker & Ruud Koopmans (2023). Politischer Protest und Radikalisierung (WZB-ProtestMonitoring). In: *MOTRA-Monitor 2022.* Wiesbaden: Bundeskriminalamt - Forschungsstelle Terrorismus/Extremismus, pp. 111-135.
- *shortened version re-published as Der "heisse Herbst" war eher heisse Luft in KATAPULT-Magazin 33/2024.*

Blog entries & other publications

[1] Stephan, Meret & **Lennart Schürmann** (2025). Wirkungsvolle Proteste: Wie antirassistische Demonstrationen Wahlen beeinflussen. *WZB Mitteilungen, 188: 10-12.*

[2] Saldivia Gonzatti, Daniel, **Lennart Schürmann** (2024). Klima- und Umweltproteste in Deutschland von 1950 bis heute. *Klimawende Ausblick 2024. Gesellschaftliche Treiber der Transformation in Deutschland* Band 1. Klimapolitik, Klimabewegung und Klimaklagen. Universität Hamburg, pp. 76-78.

[3] Lennart Schürmann (2023). Von der Straße in den Bundestag: Die lokalen Proteste von Fridays for Future zeigen starke Wirkung. *WZB Mitteilungen, 182: 6-9.*

[4] Schmidt, Leonhard, Carina Siebler, **Lennart Schürmann** & Daniel Saldivia Gonzatti (2023). Fünf Jahre Fridays for Future - Erfolge, Herausforderungen und Chancen zur Erneuerung *Blog: DVPW - Deutsche Vereinigung für Politikwissenschaft.*

[5] Siebler, Carina, Leonhard Schmidt, **Lennart Schürmann** & Daniel Saldivia Gonzatti (2023). Five years of 'Fridays for Future': but what future is there now for the movement? *The Loop. A Political Science Blog from ECPR.*
- *re-published as Five years of 'Fridays for Future': what future now? on Social Europe.*

[6] **Schürmann, Lennart**, Caroline Melches, & Stefan Herweg (2019). Minimalkompromisse machen die Eurozone nicht krisenfest. *Makronom – Online-Magazin für Wirtschaftspolitik.*

Grants, fellowships & awards

Major grants & fellowships

Empowering Voices Beyond Ballots? Representative Claims by Non-Elected Political Actors
Funding: German Academic Exchange Service (DAAD PRIME Grant, 158.227,41 €) *2025 - 2027*
Role: *Principal Investigator (Sole Applicant)*
Further Financial Support:
- Harvard University (WZB Harvard Merit Fellowship 2024/2025, *41,500$*)
- European University Institute (Max Weber Fellowship 2025/2026)

Smaller grants & scholarships (selection)

Citizens' Receptivity to Representative Claims by Non-Elected Political Actors: A Multimodal Survey Experiment (EUI Early Stage Researcher Grant)
European University Institute, 2,070€ *2026*

Conference Travel Support Grant
Institute for Humane Studies at George Mason University, 1,825$ *2025*

Professional Development Award
FAS Office for Postdoctoral Affairs at Harvard University, 500$ *2025*

Conference Travel Grant
DAAD German Academic Exchange Service, 836€ *2025*

Full PhD Scholarship
Cologne Graduate School in Management, Economics and Social Sciences, ~55,000€ *2019 - 2022*

Selten Grant for Field Work and Research Stay in Barcelona
Reinhard Selten Institute/Cluster of Excellence ECONtribute: Markets and Public Policy, ~2,000€ *2022*

International Mobility Grant
Schmittmann-Wahlen-Foundation, ~5,500€ *2015 | 2018 | 2021*

Short-Term Research Grant for Doctoral Candidates for Research Stay in Amsterdam
DAAD German Academic Exchange Service, ~6,500€ *2021*

Awards/recognition

Shortlisted (Top 3) for Tenure-Track Professor position in Computational Social Sciences
C^3S Center for Critical Computational Studies at Goethe University Frankfurt *2025*

Shortlisted (Top 3) for University Teaching Award 2022
University of Cologne *2022*

Teaching Experience

Courses

How Can Protest Change Politics?
Social Movements and Political Representation — **University of Cologne** (DE)
Instructor | Overall assessment: 4.8 (max = 5) — *Spring 2022*

- Short-listed (Top 3) for *University Teaching Award 2022* of the University of Cologne

Causes and Consequences of Political Protest:
Lessons from Environmental and Climate Mobilization in Europe — **College of Europe Natolin** (PL)
Instructor — *Spring 2026*

Environmental Protests — **University of Westminster** (UK)
Guest Lecturer — *Spring 2026*

EU Enlargement: Institutional Rationale and Citizens' Perspectives — **University of Westminster** (UK)
Guest Lecturer — *Spring 2026*

Visualizing Protest Data in the Digital Space and Beyond — **UdK Berlin University of the Arts** (DE)
Coordinating WZB Project Partner in ViSoP Visual Society Program — *Spring 2023 – Spring 2024*

Student Workshop: Applying for PhD Positions and Proposal Writing — **WZB Berlin Social Science Center** (DE)
Organizer together with Rebecca Kittel — *Fall 2023*

PhD Workshop: Creating a Webpage with R — **University of Cologne** (DE)
Organizer together with J. Bekmuratovna — *Spring 2022*

PhD Workshop: Authoring a PhD — **University of Cologne** (DE)
Organizer together with Ebru Ece Özbey — *Spring 2021*

Strategic Models of Democratic Politics — **University of Cologne** (DE)
Teaching Assistant to Chitralekha Basu — *Fall 2020*

Introduction to Quantitative Methods — **University of Cologne** (DE)
Teaching Assistant to Bruno Castanho Silva — *Fall 2019 | Fall 2020*

Applied Statistical Analysis: Political Representation by Parliamentary Elites — **Goethe University Frankfurt** (DE)
Teaching Assistant to Dominic Nyhuis — *Spring 2017*

Introduction to Statistics for Social Scientists — **University of Cologne** (DE)
Teaching Assistant to Marita Jacob — *Spring 2014 | Fall 2014 | Spring 2015*

Certificates

Max Weber Programme Teaching Certificate — **European University Institute**
Structured pedagogical training programme — *(in progress) 2025–2026*

Supervision & mentorship roles

Master's and Bachelor's theses

Marie Melchers (2024). Electoral Success of Right-Wing Populists: A Threat to Liberal Democracy? *BA Thesis (University of Münster)*

Meret Stephan (2024). Echoes of the Street: How do Pro-Migration Protests Influence Public Voting Behavior and Attitudes Regarding Migration? *MA Thesis (Humboldt University Berlin)*

Aurelia von Haugwitz (2022). Why People from the German Countryside do not Protest: Urban-rural Divergences of 'Unconventional' Political Participation. *BA Thesis (University of Cologne)*

PhD mentees

- Charlotte Grupp (since 2025) | Social and Political Science Department *(European University Institute)*
- Stefanie Oelker (since 2025) | Dynamics of Social Inequalities Department *(WZB Social Science Center)*

Student assistants

- One research intern in *Monitoring- and Transferplatform Radicalisation* project *(WZB Social Science Center)*
- Eight research assistants for coding the WZB ProtestMonitoring datasets *(WZB Social Science Center)*

Research presentations

Invited talks

Forum Offene Wissenschaft: Krise der Weltordnung(en)?, Bielefeld University *2026*
Challenges to Democratic Representation Programme Group | Job Talk, University of Amsterdam *2025*
C^{3}S Center for Critical Computational Studies | Job Talk, Goethe University Frankfurt *2025*
New Research on Europe Seminar, Minda de Gunzburg Center for European Studies, Harvard University *2025*
Discussion Series, Brandenburgische Landeszentrale für politische Bildung, Potsdam *2024*
Institutions and Political Actors Research Seminar, Pompeu Fabra University Barcelona *2022*
Hot Politics Lab Meeting, University of Amsterdam *2021*

Conferences

EUSA European Union Studies Association, Philadelphia *2025*
MPSA Midwest Political Science Association Conference, Chicago *2025*
EPSA European Political Science Association Conference *2021, 2022, 2023, 2024*
MOTRA Annual Conference, Wiesbaden *2024*
DVPW Deutsche Vereinigung für Politikwissenschaft Konferenz, University of Göttingen *2024*
COMPTEXT Interdisciplinary Conference on the Computational Text Analysis, University College Dublin *2022*
ECPR European Consortium for Political Research General Conference *2021*
IAPSS World Congress, Paris *2018*

Workshops & colloquia

Stein Rokkan Chair in Comparative Politics Colloquium, European University Institute *2025*
Max Weber Presentation, European University Institute *2025*
Center for Civil Society Research Colloquium, WZB Berlin Social Science Center *2022, 2023, 2024*
MOTRA Analysis Workshop *2023, 2024*
Contentious Politics within Civil Society Workshop, WZB Berlin Social Science Center *2024*
Extremism in Germany Workshop, University of Hamburg *2023*
Analyzing Protest in the Digital Age Workshop, WZB Social Science Center Berlin *2023*
Cologne Political Science Workshop, Cologne *2022*
Cologne-Zurich European Politics Workshop, Filzbach (CH) *2022*
Cologne Center for Comparative Politics Research Seminar, University of Cologne *2020, 2021*
Colloquium on Empirical Democracy Research, Goethe University Frankfurt *2018*

Media engagement & public outreach

Background interviews and expert opinions for Tagesschau (ARD), Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, DIE ZEIT, Quarks (WDR), nd.Aktuell (Neues Deutschland), ntv (RTL), goin' green (Seven.One), Green European Journal, Kölner Universitätsmagazin, taz-die tageszeitung, Frankfurter Rundschau & Bayerischer Rundfunk.

Speaker at public events organized by Brandenburgische Landeszentrale für politische Bildung, ZEIT-Stiftung Bucerius, Deutschlandfunk & ZEIT Campus.

Podcast appearances in Wissen unplugged/Hörsaal (Deutschlandfunk Nova), Was ist da los? Über Politik und Gesellschaft (Landeszentrale für politische Bildung Brandenburg), Quarks Daily – Dein täglicher Wissenspodcast (WDR), Wissen Weekly (Spotify Original).

Policy counseling for Members of the German Parliament (Leibniz im Bundestag).

Professional responsibilities & memberships

WZB Berlin Social Science Center
Member of Selection Committee for WZB Harvard & World Merit Fellowships 2025/26 — *2024*

University of Cologne | Cologne Graduate School in Management, Economics & Social Sciences
PhD Representative on the Cologne Graduate School Board — *2021 – 2022*

Professional Memberships

- Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA)
- European Union Studies Association (EUSA)
- German Political Science Association (DVPW)
- European Political Science Association (EPSA)
- Institute for the Study of Protest and Social Movements (ipb)

Reviewer

Journal Reviewer for: *American Political Science Review* | *American Journal of Sociology* | *Computational Communication Research* | *European Journal of Political Research* | *Italian Political Science Review/Rivista Italiana di Scienza Politica* | *Journal of Elections, Public Opinion & Parties* | *Journal of European Public Policy* | *Journal of Information Technology & Politics* | *Journal of Legislative Studies* | *Journalism* | *Legislative Studies Quarterly* | *Mobilization: an International Quarterly* | *Parliamentary Affairs* | *Political Behavior* | *Social Forces* | *Social Problems* | *West European Politics*

Other research experience

GESIS Leibniz Institute for the Social Sciences | Computational Social Science Department — **Cologne** (DE)
Research Intern with Sebastian Stier — *2019*

- Analyzed Geographic Representation on Social Media for Master's Thesis

German Federal Parliament - Bundestag | ECOFIN Committee — **Berlin** (DE)
Policy Intern — *2019*

- Preparation of Policy Positions on European Stability Mechanism

Federal Institute for Population Research | Migration and Mobility Research Group — **Wiesbaden** (DE)
Research Assistant with Heiko Rüger — *2018 – 2019*

- Development of an Online Survey for the *German Ministry of Foreign Affairs*

Goethe University Frankfurt | Chair for Comparative Politics — **Frankfurt** (DE)
Research Assistant with Thomas Zittel — *2017 – 2018*

- Developed a Dataset for the DFG Research Project *Individualized Representation and its Sources*

Max Planck Institute for the Study of Societies — **Cologne** (DE)
Research Intern | Research Assistant with Mark Lutter — *2016*

- Collected Publication Records of Social Scientists at German Universities

University of Cologne | Institute for Sociology and Social Psychology — **Cologne** (DE)
Teaching Assistant with Marita Jacob — *2014 – 2015*

- Taught *Introduction to Statistics for Social Scientists* to First Year Students

Additional skills

Languages: German (native) · English (C2) · French (B2) · Italian (A1) · Dutch (A1)
Data Analysis: R (expert) · Python (basic) · Stata (basic) · SPSS (basic)
Office & Typesetting: LaTeX+Overleaf · Microsoft Office · Apple iWork
Version Control: GitHub